The Politic
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LETTER FROM THE EDITORS

Dear readers,

We're ecstatic to share our first print edition of the year with you, an issue that features original reporting on topics of local, national, and international resonance.

This issue of *The Politic* concerns voices that have gone unheard. Adnan Bseisu writes about the silencing of conversations; he examines diplomatic expulsions as more than symbolic gestures by tracing the links between expelled ambassadors and the breakdown of geopolitical relationships. Transporting us to Alabama, Grey Battle writes about a rare win for voting rights, one that might finally account for the votes of Black Southerners that have long been ignored. Phoenix Boggs gives voice to scientists researching a dire but widely overlooked issue—insect decline, which exacerbates the climate crisis and poses a global existential threat. Our writers also amplify voices that challenge the status quo. Theo Sotoodhenia writes about the decaying relationship between the Democratic Party and rural Americans, investigating what rural populations today expect from politicians who once championed their cause. Mira Dubler-Furman interrogates how a New York City education policy that garnered broad political support is now facing pushback from some of the stakeholders it aims at helping. Eliza Daunt interviews Mishal Husain, a celebrated BBC journalist who has long illuminated urgent and difficult-to-report stories. Finally, Audrey Coombe invites us to see the grace of transitory spaces that we pass through but don't often dwell in—the train ride between New Haven and New York, the passage between winter and spring. In this issue's photo essay, Coombe pulls stills from a Super 8 reel, highlighting individual moments that would otherwise be elided into a larger film.

We extend our highest gratitude to the writers, editors, and designers who have brought our magazine to life. It's an enduring joy to work with such talented collaborators, and we are excited to share that joy with our readers in this issue.

Sincerely,
The Politic Managing Board

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SHUTTERED CONSULATES

The Impact of Diplomatic Expulsions

BY **ADNAN BSEIU**

THE WEST BANK'S setting sun painted long shadows on the ground as Husam Zomlot, the de facto Palestinian ambassador to the United States, stood on the balcony of his family home in Ramallah and gazed over the undulating hills. The air was thick with the scent of blooming olive trees, and the distant echo of playing children offered a comforting backdrop for his thoughts after a long day of government meetings. An urgent ping on his phone jolted him back to reality, foretelling a message that would shatter the calm of his world. Zomlot's diplomatic status had been revoked by the Trump Administration. The Palestinian mission in Washington D.C. was ordered to close within a month — effective October 2018 — and the Zomlot family's American visas were made invalid. Zomlot, his wife, and his two young children were to be expelled — along with a slew of career diplomats from his office.

A veteran diplomat who was born in a U.N. refugee camp in the Gaza Strip, Zomlot had long envisioned a life punctuated by the predictable ceremonies of embassy events, delicate negotiations, and cultural exchanges. As a student at Birzeit University in the West Bank, Zomlot found his voice in political activism. Following his studies, he taught as a fellow at Harvard before taking up a professorship at Birzeit. He then returned to the world of politics as the spokesperson for the Palestinian delegation to the U.N. during the Palestinian statehood campaign in 2011.

In 2017, Zomlot realized his yearslong political ambition when he was appointed as envoy to the U.S. — the equivalent of an ambassador for Palestine, a country that is not recognized by the U.S.. Zomlot and his family moved to Washington D.C. in April of that year. The weight of representing Palestine in the U.S., heavy though it was, was one he proudly embraced. Now, the country that once welcomed him — that empowered him to articulate the cause of Palestinian self-determination — was slamming its doors shut.

"My kids really enjoyed living in Washington," Zomlot told me of his children, who were five and six years old. "They were forming their first real friendships with people, so to have to withdraw them in the middle of the school year left a psychological impact," he said. "I even feel it when I leave for a couple of days and my kids become a little bit anxious… I feel it in their questions: Are you coming back? Are we staying here?"

In the days following Zomlot's expulsion, The Economist described it as "symbolic," noting that prior to the expulsion, "the Palestinian Embassy in Washington did not provide consular services, and its lobbying and public-relations work fell on deaf ears." The State Department cited a failure to "advance the start of direct and meaningful negotiations with Israel" as the Trump administration's reason for the expulsion. It urged the Palestinians not to let such a peripheral decision "distract from the imperative of reaching a peace agree-

HUSAM ZOM

ment."

The narrative of the ambassador's expulsion in the U.S. media and from government officials was riddled with rhetoric that defines the way much of us, as consumers of political media, are accustomed to viewing political banishment: while unfortunate, expulsions are emblematic of the spirit of the time, not effective drivers of that spirit.

WHEN I SPOKE TO ZOMLOT, who has now landed on his feet as the Palestinian ambassador to the United Kingdom, he told me that Trump's edict transcended symbolism. "It's not just symbolic," Zomlot lamented. "It is practical. An embassy sustains the relationship on a daily basis." Zomlot described how the closure of the mission meant that tens of thousands of Palestinian-Americans were left without a central hub to celebrate their culture, heritage, and achievements. Many found it increasingly challenging to find spaces where they could express their Palestinian identity, let alone coordinate travel to and from Palestine.

Beyond administrative tasks, Zomlot explained that the embassy played a vital role in fostering diplomatic relations between the U.S. and Palestine. He recalled being instrumental in facilitating Palestinian President Mahmoud Abbas's visit to Washington and then-President Donald Trump's subsequent trip to the West Bank in 2017. These trips, Zomlot emphasized, were not just ceremonial, but crucial diplomatic endeavors that strengthened ties between the U.S. and Palestine and laid the groundwork for the potential peace plan Trump had promised. Zomlot has a point: every American president since Bill Clinton has indulged Palestinian leadership by visiting the West Bank, and both Palestinian presidents during that time have reciprocated with trips to Washington. Since the

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closure of the Palestinian embassy, neither country's president has undertaken such a visit, which Zomlot said has deprived them of the opportunity to "really engage, understand, and initiate."

As I listened to Zomlot explain the effects of being kicked out of the U.S., something more subtle than the loss of diplomacy struck me as un-symbolic: by expelling Zomlot, the U.S. had very tangibly eroded its trustworthiness as a broker in any potential peace negotiations in the eyes of the Palestinians. At the time, media coverage of Zomlot's expulsion opted not to explore its practical ramifications, stopping its analysis at the symbolic affront to the Palestinian people as a whole.

More pertinent than its symbolism is that many Palestinians viewed the humiliation of Zomlot and his family as a form of deep-rooted contempt for the Palestinian cause. Hanan Ashrawi, one of Palestine's eminent activists and political leaders, accused the U.S. of extortion: "The U.S. has taken its attempts to pressure and blackmail the Palestinians to a new level," Ashrawi said. Saeb Erakat, Palestine's chief negotiator for decades, was less sparing: "[The expulsion] is yet another affirmation of the Trump administration's policy to collectively punish the Palestinian people," he said in the media in response to the expulsion.

Zomlot agreed, claiming that his expulsion served as yet more evidence to the Palestinian people that the Trump administration was conspiring against them. When Trump unveiled his infamous "two-state" peace plan two years later in 2020, it was dead on arrival: the Palestinians, who were being asked to come to the negotiating table, were not going to reward American bad faith. Palestinians, Zomlot argued, felt as if "taking out the Palestinian voice [via his expulsion] was a key part of the plan."

The tale of Husam Zomlot tells a very different story than the narrative of symbolism The Economist depicted at the time. Perhaps because diplomatic expulsions are instantaneously covered by the media and rarely revisited retrospectively, we often fail to appreciate how consequential they can be. The Economist painted the embassy closure as illustrative of the frailty of the Palestinian cause in the U.S.: "Far from winning a state, it could not even keep an office in Georgetown," it quipped. But for the Palestinians, the expulsion of their ambassador instigated — in very real terms — a further breakdown in the US-Palestinian relationship and the end of direct, good-faith communication.

At the very end of our conversation, Zomlot outlined his hopes for the potential Israel-Saudi normalization deal, which the U.S. is brokering to reconcile the demands of both sides: trade for Israel and security guarantees, nuclear power, and an improvement of the Palestinian condition for Saudi Arabia. Zomlot, optimistic about the deal, noted that the Saudis are responsible for negoti ating on the Palestinians' behalf as to what the last condition entails. Had he kept his post in Washington, he hypothesized, he might have been involved in direct talks with the State Department. "The lack of our presence [in Washington] has made [Israel-Saudi negotiations] more difficult," he admitted. This deal is yet another example of how different significant international negotiations might have been had Zomlot not been expelled.

A FRENCH AMBASSADOR I SPOKE WITH who was recently expelled — and who requested anonymity — offered a different perspective on his own expulsion. He was adamant that there was nothing the French government could have done to prevent it: his banishment, he argued, was truly symbolic.

"The first symbol a country will turn to when it wants to mark its dissonance with the French is obviously to get rid of the [French] ambassador," the ambassador explained. "The regime had already adopted an anti-French stance… so I was nothing more than the involuntary symbol of a very strong political movement."

Beyond blaming an antagonistic host government, the ambassador traced his expulsion to "post-colonial malaise." Recalling the generations of people who had massed frustration against and resentment towards the French following the host country's independence, he argued that a political retreat was inevitable.

To admit that an expulsion is partially un-symbolic is to accept that acting to prevent it might have been worthwhile. The French ambassador's attitude, which suggests that the hands of his country were tied, contradicts the official account of the government that ordered his withdrawal. It clarified that it was seeking the withdrawal of this specific ambassador because of actions he took that eroded their trust in him, not because of a recalibration of the country's relationship with the French entirely. Of course, singling out an ambassador for expulsion doesn't speak well of those bilateral relations. In fact, it materially hurts them in the short term. Along with the ambassador, the French government was forced to withdraw its troops from the host country as well.

But adopting a lens of symbolism potentially aggravates the diplomatic relationship at hand. Rather than appointing a new ambassador as was asked of him, French President Emmanuel Macron refused, keeping the ambassador I spoke with

on the payroll for "consultations" in Paris. Those consultations have done little to rebuild trust with the host country's government: even the ambassador conceded that he does not expect to return anytime soon. Had the French accepted a sense of agency and dispatched a new ambassador, would their interests be better served? While the ambassador answered that question with a resounding no, it is difficult to justify that the situation on the ground would not have been different with an ambassador living in the host country. It might be unproductive, then, to paint the French ambassador's expulsion with a purely symbolic brush.

The French ambassador denies that paradigm entirely and contends that the host country's "distrust" in him was an excuse for a conscious and inevitable shift away from France. "They had already chosen us as a political alien," he said. "They had already decided to attack us and had already considered France as an enemy." In other words, even if France were to appoint a new ambassador, the host government would undoubtedly conjure an excuse to shun them, too.

To further press the ambassador, I put forward the case of the attempted expulsion of French ambassador to Niger Sylvain Itté, who, at the time of our interview, was being held captive by the military junta after President Macron refused the new government's request for his withdrawal. The ambassador conceded that the delicacy of the matter—and Macron's attention to it—suggested that something more than symbolism was at play. Indeed, Macron's refusal to withdraw the ambassador suggests a belief that he could have affected the outcome of the withdrawal request, undermining the narrative of diplomatic expulsions as purely symbolic. Macron was forced to eventually withdraw the ambassador, resigning himself to a new reality of diminished French influence in Niger.

MATTHEW FUHRMANN is a visiting professor of political science at Yale and an expert on international security issues relating to diplomacy and bargaining. When I recounted the stark differences in Zomlot and the French ambassadors' postures towards symbolism to Fuhrmann, he proposed a conceptual framework that could accommodate both. "Expulsions serve three main functions," he explained: a symbolic function, a coercive function, and a deterrence function.

The symbolic classification very much echoes the French ambassador's description of his expulsion. Whereas symbolism concerns signaling without tangible outcomes, coercive expulsions serve to materially weaken the other side's position during negotiations. Deterrence expulsions, meanwhile, manifest as nonbelligerent warnings not to repeat an unwanted action.

While Fuhrmann acknowledged that expulsions can fall into the symbolic category in theory, he pointed out that, in practice, misperceptions can complicate intended symbolism. "In international politics, messages are misinterpreted all the time," he said. "It's totally plausible to me that you might expel a diplomat for one reason, but the country where the diplomat is coming from might see a totally different motivation for your behavior."

It is conceivable, therefore, that an expulsion seen domestically as symbolic could be compellent in effect. The Trump administration might have sincerely believed that it was shuttering a token cultural attaché, but it would come to realize years later, upon the repudiation of its peace plan, that its calculus eclipsed a mere rejection of ceremonial diplomacy.

THROUGH THE CONVERSATIONS with Zomlot and thre French ambassador, it becomes clear that the threads of symbolism and reality are interwoven so tightly in the tapestry of diplomacy that it can be impossible to discern one from the other. When viewed merely as a form of political theater, expulsions are often unjustly overlooked. Indeed, their portrayal as symbolic gestures provides a comfortable veil for nations to hide behind, absolving them from any genuine introspection or accountability.

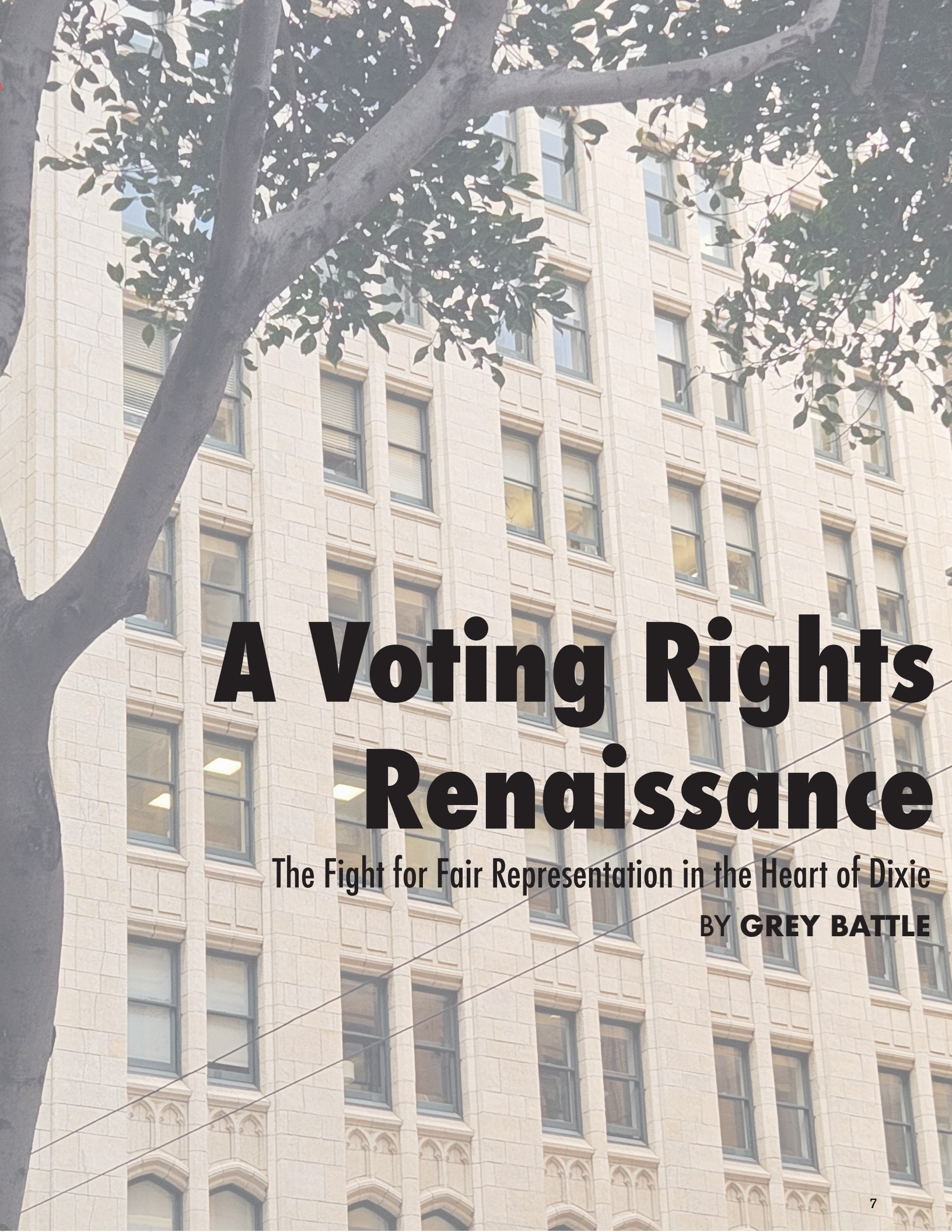
Husam Zomlot's story is a poignant reminder of this. The implications of his expulsion from the U.S. extended far beyond symbolism. For him and the Palestinian community, it was an intentional tear to the fabric of a diplomatic relationship they had sewn over many decades. Zomlot's chronicle reveals that the chasm between intent and perception is a breeding ground for misunderstanding, further complicating the delicate dance of diplomacy. That very chronicle, Furhmann posited, was likely nothing more for the White House than an impulsive decision made by President Trump.

Similarly, the French ambassador's rhetoric compels us to confront some unsettling realities: Does conveniently labeling expulsions as symbolic allow nations to sidestep responsibility for what comes from them? Does such a mindset not only breed complacency but also a cycle of diplomatic missteps?

Husam Zomlot and the French ambassador were not the first diplomats to be expelled from their host countries, nor will they be the last. Each expulsion adopts a unique and particular form—generalizing their characteristics is unproductive, unless you reject the prospect of symbolism outright.

That being said, the next time you encounter an expulsion, ask yourself if the symbolic lens through which it is displayed captures the true resolution of the diplomatic situation at hand. Perhaps you will find that it blurs the image, proffering a plea for a lack of accountability. You might even find that the intended symbolism rarely seeps through. Indeed, the human tendency to exaggerate potential threats challenges the plausibility of purely symbolic expulsions at all.

Diplomacy—the art of political discussion—begets very real consequences by nature, and the whereabouts of bumptious diplomats should be no exception. By recognizing this, we can become ever-so-slightly more effective diplomatic practitioners. In a world where one misperception can spark a devastating war, that upgrade matters. So, should you ever contemplate expelling an ambassador after launching a military coup, remember that the quiet whispers of an expulsion can quickly become the loud gestures of aggression.



A Voting Rights Renaissance

The Fight for Fair Representation in the Heart of Dixie

BY **GREY BATTLE**

"I'M SIX GENERATIONS REMOVED from enslavement on my mom's side, my daughter and son are seven generations removed," said Evan Milligan. "These things aren't abstract concepts to me." Milligan is a careful speaker with a deep, Southern accent, and an unwavering commitment to civil advocacy. He is the lead plaintiff in the Supreme Court's landmark *Allen v. Milligan* redistricting case. For him, the decision is connected to a 200-year-old fight over voting power.

In the 5-4 ruling handed down on June 8, 2023, the Supreme Court declared that Alabama's 2021 congressional district map violates the Voting Rights Act of 1965. Chief Justice John Roberts and Justice Brett Kavanaugh joined the Court's 3 liberal justices, in a ruling that requires the state to redraw their map to include an additional majority-minority district.

The decision will have ripple effects throughout the South and will change the power dynamics of national electoral politics to favor the Democratic Party. The next moves of Democratic Leadership will decide the strength and duration of the ruling's impact.

Milligan was initially brought onto the case because of his work in voter mobilization as Executive Director of Alabama Forward. He joined a recurring coalition meeting to coordinate strategy leading up to the November 2020 election alongside over 30 other civic engagement groups working across Alabama. During the state's 2021 redistricting, group members turned their focus to providing information about redistricting and fundraising for grassroots outreach.

A coalition of Black voters challenged Alabama's map on the basis that it "packed and cracked" communities of color into districts that dilute their political power. "Cracking" dilutes the power of Black voters by spreading predominantly Black neighborhoods across many districts, while "packing" concentrates Black voting power into one district and reduces their power in other districts.

The 2021 Alabama map proposal employed both strategies, packing a large number of Black Alabamians into Congressional District 7, while spreading neighborhoods with predominantly Black residents across Districts 1, 2, and 3. The map allows six majority-white districts to cross county lines and distorts the makeup of the Alabama population. Black people make up 27% of the state's population but hold a majority in only 1 out of 7 districts.

Alabama's legacy of voter suppression casts a shadow over election day. After the first of the Voting Rights Marches in Alabama sparked national outrage, the Voting Rights Act of 1965 (VRA) was signed into law by President Lyndon B. Johnson. On what is now known as "Bloody Sunday," state troopers attacked nearly 600 protest-

“The Civil Rights Movement and the Voting Rights Movement were born here in Montgomery, Alabama. Alabama is the birthplace of some very oppressive systems, and also the birthplace of some really innovative freedom fighters.”

ers on the Edmund Pettus Bridge in Selma, Alabama. Television cameras captured the assault, transforming the protest into a national symbol for the civil rights movement. When video of the protest aired that night, Americans across the country listened to the cheers of white bystanders, watching as deputies swung clubs, whips, and rubber tubing wrapped in barbed wire at men, women, and children. Milligan said Bloody Sunday was tragic, but pivotal to the passage of the VRA. “That was why they marched. This is a part of our legacy.”

Upon its adoption, the VRA eliminated poll taxes and literacy tests that were proven to be discriminatory against Black voters. Section 5 of the law required that states with histories of disenfranchisement—including Alabama and six other states—receive federal approval for any changes related to elections and voting. The U.S. Justice Department used Section 5 to block over 700 discriminatory voting changes between 1969 and 2008, 100 of which were proposed in Alabama.

However, the Supreme Court unraveled the VRA safety net and gutted Section 5 in the 2013 *Shelby County, Alabama v. Holder* decision. The 5-4 ruling created momentum for policies to suppress Black voters in states that had previously been limited by federal oversight. Within weeks of the ruling, five states—including Alabama—that were previously barred by federal preclearance enacted restrictive photo ID laws.

Alabama intentionally crafted new, statewide voting requirements that were difficult to comply with. A voter identification law, signed by former Governor Robert Bentley, came into effect in 2014, the same year that 12 rural Department of Motor Vehicles locations closed. For many Alabamians, the closest DMV is counties away. In counties with limited transportation, a photo ID is now nearly impossible to obtain.

Because Alabama is an innovator of regressive policy, Robyn Hyden said she feels greater pressure to innovate social change in response. “The Civil Rights Movement and the Voting Rights Movement were born here in Montgomery, Alabama. Alabama is the birthplace of some very oppressive systems, and also the birthplace of some really innovative freedom fighters.”

Hyden is the executive director of Alabama Arise, an organization that advances legislation to protect and strengthen voting rights. “What you would hear is just the voter apathy, and people who are struggling to participate, but really didn’t understand why it was so hard,” Hyden said. “Overlapping, complicated barriers to voting have been compounding.”

Even with the new Supreme Court decision, conservative lawmakers in Alabama have continued their attempts to suppress Black voters.

Since *Milligan*, the GOP-controlled legislature approved a new map with only one majority-Black district. After plaintiffs filed complaints, federal judges found the new map was a racial gerrymander on October 4, 2023. An independent mapmaker crafted three options. A three-judge panel of the U.S. District Court for the Northern District of Alabama chose a map that increases the percentage of Black voters in one district from 30% to 48.7% and preserves the existing majority-Black district.

But the legal battle is not over yet. While Secretary of State Wesley Allen said his office would implement the map that “the federal court has forced upon Alabama” for the 2024 election cycle, he signaled the state would soon appeal the map afterwards. “It is important for all Alabamians to know that the legal portion of this process has not yet been completed. A full hearing on the redistricting issue will take place in the future,” Allen said in a statement on October 5, 2023.

THE SUPREME COURT IS THE LAST HURDLE through which state policy must pass, a critical mechanism to check Alabama lawmakers and protect those marginalized by the state. The Court’s current makeup, however, may be more likely than ever to tolerate maps that voting rights advocates deem racist.

“Alabama is defying the Supreme Court and continuing to push forward maps that do not comply with the court’s order. And they’re doing this because they think that the court might revisit it,” said David Daley, the author of the book *Rat-f**ked: Why Your Vote Doesn’t Count*. Since publishing his first book in 2016, Daley has dedicated his time to researching, writing, and speaking about this topic.

“You’ll see a new map in Alabama ahead of 2024. It will probably be a map with two districts where Black voters in Alabama have the opportunity to choose a limited number of [representatives],” Daley said. “It’s hard to imagine that those seats would last the decade, that those maps would last a decade, this Court has been pretty clear in the direction that it’s going on race, on affirmative action, and on voting rights. And it’s not in the direction of greater fairness,” he continued.

Daley sees *Allen v. Milligan* as an opening for the court to eliminate consideration of race from the redistricting process entirely. He views Kavanaugh’s concurrence as an invitation to strike down Section 2 of the VRA. Kavanaugh wrote that “the authority to conduct race-based redistricting

“While I do think we are to celebrate the decision in *Milligan*, it’s simply one skirmish and alert in a longer game, and the longer game isn’t over yet.”

cannot extend indefinitely into the future.” The justice clarified, though, that this case did not raise the question of how much longer Section 2 of the VRA should survive. “Alabama did not raise that temporal argument in this Court, and I therefore would not consider it at this time,” he wrote. But the implication was clear—there is a strong chance that Kavanaugh would be willing to engage with this argument in the future.

Daley said lawyers in states such as Louisiana “immediately filed briefs along the lines Kavanaugh suggested, saying that it was not necessary to have racial preferences used in redistricting.” Daley fears Section 2 of the VRA may face a similar fate to the court’s recent affirmative action decision. “We will see this litigated before the court, perhaps even in its next session. These lawyers recognize an invitation from the court when they see it,” he said.

Chief Justice John Roberts has been suspicious of Section 2 of the VRA since he came to Washington. As a young aide in the Justice Department, he worked against the VRA’s 1982 reauthorization. As a special assistant, Roberts wrote more than 25 memos opposing the House bill’s version of Section 2. He also drafted talking points, speeches, and op-eds, prepared officials for Senate testimony, attended weekly strategy sessions, and worked closely with Republican senators to weaken the bill.

“I think those who were surprised missed the way that Roberts works. Roberts, when he is going after major decisions like this, prefers to go slowly. He does a half step before he does the full step,” Daley said. Daley believes that Roberts has knives out for Section 2 of the VRA. “While I do think we are to celebrate the decision in *Milligan*, it’s simply one skirmish and alert in a longer game, and the longer game isn’t over yet,” Daley said.

ADVOCATES CELEBRATED the *Milligan* utcome as a rare win for voting rights, as did Democratic elected officials at both the state and national levels. Terri Sewell, the representative for the state’s 7th Congressional District and the sole Democrat that Alabama sends to Washington D.C., said in a statement that the decision was a “victory for Black voters in Alabama and for the promise of fair representation.” The statements of other prominent Democrats echoed these sentiments.

The *Milligan* decision helps to protect equal voting access, but it also presents a powerful political opportunity for Democrats. Black residents who were previously unable to vote or whose votes held little weight can now mobilize in support of progressive causes.

Milligan believes the right to vote can be a driver of transformative social change. “We’re interested in freedom, democracy, health and welfare of poor communities— communities that are distanced from power,” he said. “In a functional, constitutional, representative democracy, the right to vote is inherent to be able to have any sort of equity or real broad participation within government.”

Hyden similarly believes that enfranchising Black voters will be a critical first step in reducing what she perceives as institutional inequality. “Health care funding, public transit, childcare, addressing inequities in our criminal justice system, fines and fees which are disproportionately burdening low wealth people… these are all systemic inequities that we have to address through elected representatives,” she said.

In Alabama, 80% of Black voters are registered as Democrats, and 96% supported the Democratic candidate in the 2017 Senate election. A congressional map that more accurately reflects Alabama’s population will likely constitute new access to votes for southern Democrats.

Hyden views the *Milligan* decision as an avenue to expand Black representation in Alabama politics. Although a quarter of the state’s population is Black, not a single Black person holds statewide elected office, a position on the Alabama Supreme Court, or a spot on either appeals court. “Voters don’t have proper representation. We do not have leaders who come from our communities who look like us who share our beliefs,” she said. “Some of that is driven by gerrymandering and some of that is driven by voter disenfranchisement.”

“It’s important to remember that Alabama and the South as a whole actually has the highest concentration of Black voters and LGBTQ voters in the country,” said Hyden. She gestured to reductive stereotypes of Alabama as a backwater state, made up of poor and uneducated white people. She said there is a sense that Alabamians “get the government they deserve.”

But in the 2012, 2016, and 2020 presidential elections, the Democratic vote in Alabama was at or above 35%. “There’s a lot of misconceptions about who is here and what we want in our elected officials. We may not have the voting majority to get some of the pro-

gressive policies that we would like to see. But there are a lot of people here fighting and working hard to make change," Hyden said.

She believes the *Allen v. Milligan* decision could boost these efforts. "My hope would be that people are more engaged in the process and that they feel that their vote counts," said Hyden.

For activists, the effort to ensure a fair voting map for Black voters without a seat at the table can feel hopeless.

"It's like trying to fight in a Royal Rumble with your hands tied behind your back because only so many people are going to have the time to serve in this capacity," Milligan said. "Only so many legal services organizations have the funding and the time to spend in our case."

Benard Simelton views the *Allen v. Milligan* decision as a call to action, an opportunity to amplify the voices of Black voters and encourage them to run for office themselves. "We need to train candidates, educate them on how to run for office, and then the Democratic Party needs to make sure that they follow through on the state level, as well as the national level," he said.

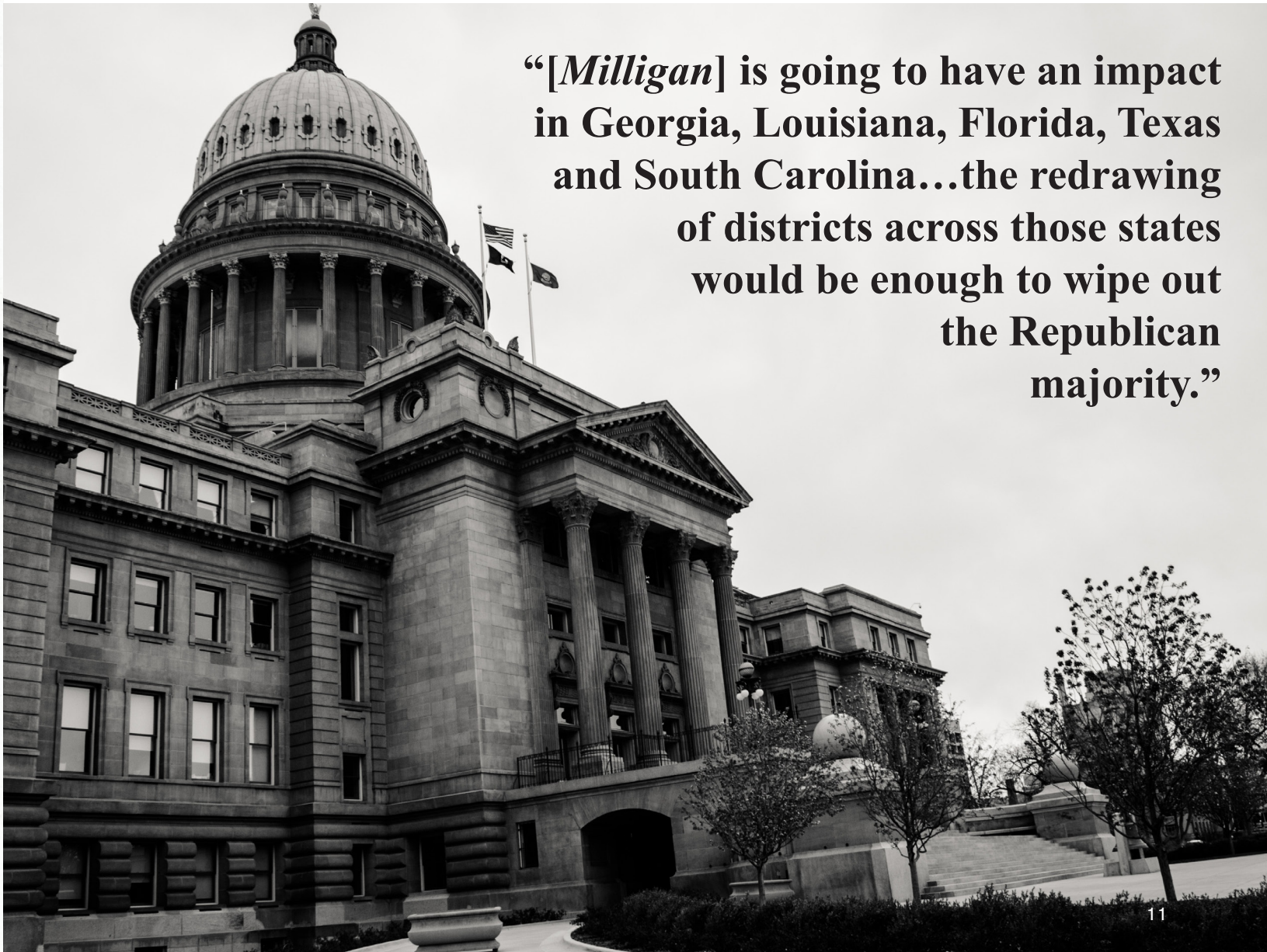
Nathaniel Rakich, a senior elections analyst at the website *FiveThirtyEight*, said the decision could spill over to influence election results throughout the South. He predicts *Allen v. Milligan* will embolden Democrats and voting rights groups pursuing similar lawsuits in Louisiana, Florida, and North Carolina. The precedent set by the decision increases the likelihood that lower courts come to a similar conclusion as the Supreme Court.

Rakich also said the decision could reinvigorate local Democratic organizing, in states where the party has become nearly invisible. "If you are a Black Democrat living in a district that's currently Republican, but is going to become Democratic, your local Democratic Party is going to become stronger and more energized," he said.

"[*Milligan*] is going to have an impact in Georgia, Louisiana, Florida, Texas and South Carolina… the redrawing of districts across those states would be enough to wipe out the Republican majority," said Chuck Bullock, a professor at the University of Georgia. Bullock is described by colleagues as the grandfather of Southern Politics.

"For the Democratic Party, this is a great ruling," Bullock said. "[Republicans] want nothing more than to keep the status quo how it is. Their easiest plan is to pack minorities in as few districts with as many numbers as possible. So, if you spread out the Democratic electorate in more than one district, then it makes Democrats naturally more viable in Southern politics."

The untapped Democratic potential in states like Alabama could be a tipping point for the Party. "Those Democratic seats at the margins could be the difference between which party has majority control in the House," said Seth McKee, a professor at the University of Oklahoma who researches political realignment in the South. "This is huge. I mean, it really changes the playing field in terms of the outcome of who has power nationally."



“We’re doing something that is really a tradition of this type of advocacy, certainly coming out of Black freedom movements. It started during emancipation— but prior to emancipation groups— with enslaved people.”

MILLIGAN VIEWS THE RULING as a platform to discuss Alabama’s history of voter suppression, and build momentum for federally-enshrined legislation to secure voting rights. “I think about the legacy of systems of racial oppression–excluding groups from building financial and political power because of [their] racial identity,” Milligan said, “That’s what’s driving us.”

He works best when he’s on the ground: at marches, speeches, community events, or while canvassing door-to-door. “We’re having conversations about human rights, we’re having conversations about remembrance, we’re looking at tragedies related to enslavement, lynching, and segregation, contemporary tragedies related to the death penalty and incarceration… conversations about those things in length, which people can understand. I think that is just really beautiful, honestly, to be a part of,” he said.

The work is taxing, but Milligan can’t imagine his life without public service. For him, politics is personal. He said his advocacy is so much a part of his story that “it can be difficult to discern where the work starts.” Milligan was raised in Montgomery, surrounded by stories of activism during the Jim Crow era from friends, family, and community members.

“We’re doing something that is really a tradition of this type of advocacy, certainly coming out of Black freedom movements. It started during emancipation— but prior to emancipation groups— with enslaved people,” said Milligan.

According to Evan Milligan, this decision is a gamechanger. “Alabama’s best days are ahead of us,” Milligan said. “We have everything we need to be a leader in the 21st century.”

AND THEN THERE WERE NONE

Unraveling the Insect Apocalypse

BY PHOENIX BOGGS

WHEN I WAS in Kindergaten,September was a magical time. As the teachers let us out of class for recess, we would sprint toward the playground, jumping in the air, whooping, cupping our hands together, trying to catch the elusive pairs of black and red insects that abounded around us. September passed this way until, suddenly, all the bugs would disappear. Adults were left to scrub their car windshields clean while we forlornly returned to our bugless swing sets and slides. Come May, though, the cycle would always begin again.

September and May were lovebug breeding seasons in Florida, when swarms of these unique bugs, commonly seen in pairs, would descend upon homes, roads, and playgrounds.

This past May, I realized I couldn't remember the last time I saw a lovebug. At some point between kindergarten and college, all the lovebugs had disappeared—this time, for good. My lovebug mystery is not the only "missing persons" case that has developed recently in the insect world. Across the globe, insect populations have declined precipitously, causing major consequences for global ecosystems and food networks.

THESE DECLINES ARE taking place on a major scale. Some scientists estimate there has been as much as a 75% reduction in insect biomass worldwide in the last 50 years. Insects are going extinct eight times faster than mammals, birds, or reptiles.

Dave Goulson, a professor of biology at the University of Sussex, is a leading world authority on insect declines. His recent book, *Silent Earth: Averting the Insect Apocalypse,* describes the perils of insect population loss and assesses the current situation.

"[The rate of decline] varies geographically and depends on which group of insects you look at," Goulson told *The Politic.* "Some of the more dramatic rates of decline seem really alarming."

Researchers from Radboud University sounded an early alarm about insect deaths in one 2017 study. The study, which analyzed insect populations in German nature reserves, found a 76% decline in insect biomass over 27 years. It's difficult to estimate how quickly insects are dying across different habitats, biomes, and continents, but scientists generally accept that insects are declining globally by about one to two percent per year.

Environmentalists aren't the only ones who fear a world without insects. Insect decline is certain to have disastrous consequences, as the species at risk are essential to global agricultural and ecological systems. They're the pollinators who tend our crops and the predators who consume our pests. Between pollination and pest control, estimates suggest that insects contribute at least $57 billion of value to the US economy every year.

According to Goulson, if insects continue to disappear at current rates, humans will soon feel the impact at the dinner table.

"If insect populations continue to fall, and at the same time the human population continues to rise, then something's gotta give," the professor said. "It won't affect people in rich countries terribly much because most of us can afford to pay more for our food. But in developing countries where they're already struggling to afford food, that's where it's really going to hurt. Ultimately, millions, possibly billions, of people could die."

Goulson's prediction is supported by a body of evidence demonstrating that insects are essential for global food systems. The U.S. Natural Resources Conservation Service reports that 35% of the world's food crops depend on pollinators, and food crops are overwhelmingly reliant on insects as predators that eliminate pests. These species—not only honeybees, but also beetles, flies, ladybugs, and countless others—are fundamental for food production. If insect declines continue, scientists agree it will be nearly impossible to produce enough crops to feed the world's population.

Already, agricultural production chains are feeling the effects of insect loss. Across the

world, farmers are searching for solutions to decreasing crop yields caused by a lack of pollination. In one case, bee declines forced farmers in China's Sichuan province to pollinate their apple orchards by hand, using chicken feathers to spread pollen from one tree to another. Hand pollination is notoriously costly, but is becoming increasingly necessary for farmers worldwide.

Insect loss won't only affect the diets of humans. Insects are the cornerstones of countless food webs as the primary prey of many reptiles, birds, and amphibians. The interactions between insects and their predators are so complex that scientists cannot map them out precisely. That means that we are in the dark about how far we are from famine and scarcity. We will only know once enough essential species disappear—and we feel the consequences.

"One question people sometimes ask is, how will we know when all the insects are extinct? Well, we won't because we'll be gone before then," said Dr. Eliza Grames, a Biology professor at Binghamton University who focuses on insect biodiversity. "The insects will outlast us, for sure."

The importance of insects in world production chains means that their loss will likely have complex downstream effects. Marta Wells is an insect specialist and professor of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology at Yale. She notes that agricultural breakdowns from insect declines could radically transform the geopolitical landscape.

"In places where there are no insects, there will be less food. When people can't eat, they'll migrate. And when they migrate, people in other countries will feel the effects," Wells said.

Insect loss will have many disastrous consequences, but won't it also remove mosquitoes, ticks, and other bugs that are irritating or dangerous to humans? In an ironic twist of fate, the answer appears to be "no." Goulson says the insects that ravage our crops and disrupt our picnics are in fact poised for success in the human world.

"Highly mobile, fast-breeding insects with a short generation time and a capacity to increase their population very quickly have proved to be quite resilient," Goulson said. "And if they're lucky enough to be insects that thrive in man-made habitats, or like to eat crops that humans grow a lot of, then they will do very well."

A world of declining insect populations, Goulson argues, is not a world without mosquitoes or aphids. It will be a world without spiders or butterflies or ladybugs, the creatures that overwhelmingly help, not hurt, us.

"We're never going to drive all insects extinct. Some of them are very tough and are actually doing quite well," Goulson said. "But they're a minority, and annoyingly for us, they tend to be the ones that are harmful to us or our crops."

FOR YEARS, scientists have sought a precise answer to the mystery of insect declines. Are insects being wiped out by habitat loss or by climate change? Pollution or pesticides? Eventually, scientists arrived at an unfortunate conclusion: all these factors are driving insect declines.

"The factors work together," Wells said. "First, we destroy the habitat. Then, we plant corn and create a monoculture, reducing the number of insects that can live there. Then, on top, we add pesticides."

In *Silent Earth*, Goulson likens the insect crisis to the Agatha Christie novel *Murder on the Orient Express.* In this classic mystery tale, there is no single murderer – every suspect had a hand in the victim's death. Goulson sees a similar story in the insect crisis: it's not one factor, but many, that causes insect declines. Grames agrees that the varieties of insect species and behaviors makes it tricky to find one easy answer. She points to data from California as an example.

"Researchers have been collecting data from butterfly communities in the low elevations in the Central Valley of California, then at some high elevations in the Sierras. The data shows that from the 1970s to the 2000s, butterfly declines in the valleys have been caused by habitat loss and pesticides. But at higher elevations, the populations were relatively stable," Grames told *The Politic*. "Then, over the last 20 years, the higher elevation populations have declined because of climate change. So, [there are] different causes in different settings."

Climate change is an emerging issue in the conversation about insect declines. Temperature and seasonal changes could greatly impact insect populations, which rely on these seasonal markers for essential behaviors. Nevertheless, both Goulson and Grames feel climate change has not affected insects as much as other factors such as habitat loss or pesticides. Specifically, Goulson points out "land use change," a term ecologists frequently use to describe all human actions that alter the wild state of an environment. This term encompasses actions as diverse as deforestation, resource extraction, construction, and agriculture.

"A lot of people want to jump to climate change as the biggest factor. But historically, land use change has been what's driving declines," Grames said. "In the future, climate change will be a bigger issue, and we're starting to see that in some places. But it's not the final stab on the Orient Express."

That 'final stab' is a topic of fierce debate in insect ecology. Still, Goulson and Grames agree that habitat loss, or more generally "land use change," is the prime suspect.

"Globally, habitat loss is the biggest driver. We've been radically changing habitats for many centuries. Habitat loss is also interwoven with the intensification of farming and pesticides because a lot of that habitat loss is to clear land for agriculture,"

Goulson said. "It's hard to disentangle."

When Goulson mentions farming and pesticides, he refers to the catastrophic effects of insect-killing chemicals on the natural world. For example, bee declines—which have dominated media coverage of insects in recent years—are tied closely to pesticide use. The World Animal Foundation reports that in 2018, U.S. beekeepers lost as much as 40 percent of their honeybee colonies. A major cause was a class of pesticides known as neonicotinoids.

Neonicotinoids are infamous for wreaking havoc on insect populations. Known as neonics for short, these pesticides were first registered for agricultural use in the 1990s, after which their popularity exploded. Today, they are the most widely used insecticide in the world.

Neonics work by permanently binding to insects' nerve cells, overstimulating and destroying them. Affected insects exhibit uncontrollable shaking followed by paralysis and death. Notably, scientists agree that only 2 to 5% of neonic chemicals make it into the target plant: more than 95% seep into the surrounding environment. One 2015 study by the U.S. Geological Survey found neonic pollution in more than 50% of streams it sampled across the country.

The most striking fact about neonics, besides their xenocidal effects on insects, is that farmers often do not need to use them at all. Neonics are used prophylactically — in other words, whether the farmer has a pest problem or not. Wendy Kerner, an environmental attorney who specializes in neonicotinoid use, believes that many farmers who use these deadly pesticides could achieve equal crop yields without them.

"Peer-reviewed and independent study after study show that there's no increased yield when farmers use neonicotinoids," said Kerner. "But the farmers are just resigned to it; it's the way they've always done it. It's the status quo."

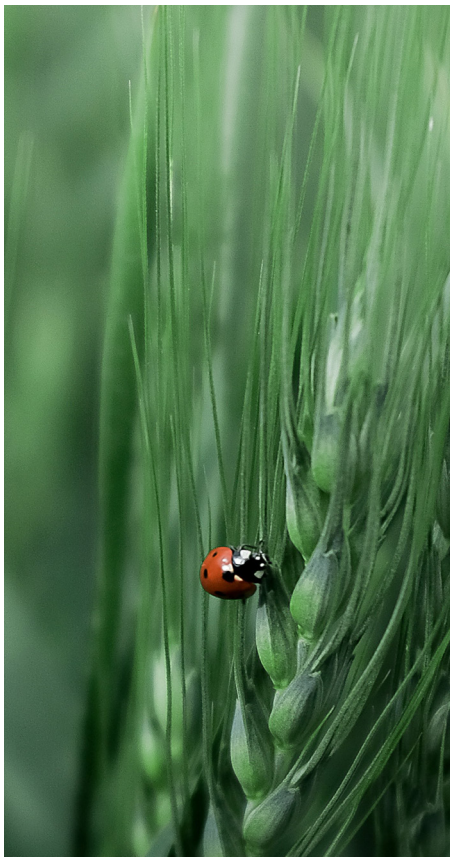
EUROPEAN POLICY MAKERS have taken considerable action to protect insects from neonics. In 2013, the European Union banned three kinds of neonics on flowering crops to protect pollinators. However, the chemicals continued to contaminate bee colonies. Even if flowering crops were free from neonics, non-flowering crops still leeched the chemicals into the soil and groundwater, where it was absorbed by wildflowers and other plants bees love. So, in 2018, the European Union extended the ban to all field crops.

Meanwhile, in the United States, neonicotinoid use is pervasive, even on flowering crops. According to Kerner, almost 100% of non-organic corn is grown with neonicotinoid-treated seeds. For soybeans, the rate is about 75%. She noted that U.S. environmental regulation standards make it difficult to implement pesticide restrictions as binding as the European Union's.

"I think that one of the biggest reasons we have this problem in our country is because of our regulatory principles," Kerner said. "The E.U. banned neonics because they operate under the precautionary principle, where the industry has to show governmental regulators that their chemicals won't harm the environment. In the U.S., we fast-track these pesticides, register them, and then wait to see what happens."

In 2013, U.S. Representative Earl Blumenauer (D-OR) introduced a federal bill to suspend the registration of neonic pesticides. The bill, entitled the "Save America's Pollinators Act," would crack down on neonic seed dressings, which are currently exempt from many regulations. However, the bill—which Blumenauer most recently reintroduced to Congress last June—has never picked up debate or speed. According to Kerner, this is in large part due to the powerful persuasion tactics of agricultural companies.

"The industry pushes back on



every level and in every way that they can," said Kerner. "Primarily, they try to downplay the science or mislead the public with their own self-funded studies. They also have strong lobbying groups that lobby against these regulations at state and federal levels."

As a bloc, agribusiness companies spend more than $90 million a year on federal lobbying efforts, making them one of the most powerful private interests in Congress. These companies also frequently hire EPA employees after they leave the public sector, creating a complex system of conflicts of interest that work against meaningful pesticide legislation.

But just as the causes of the insect crisis are varied, so are the solutions. To halt or reverse insect death, governments and corporations must work to stop habitat loss, plant and protect native plants, cease using dangerous pesticides, and fight climate change—a tough bill to foot.

BUT SOLUTIONS CAN start small. Grames, the insect biodiversity researcher, feels that one simple change could drastically change the fate of American insect populations.

"Insects need to be classified legally as wildlife within states. Right now, few states consider insects to be wildlife. So state conservation or fish and wildlife departments can't work on insect conservation. Their hands are tied," Grames said. "I think within the U.S., that's the best thing that could possibly happen because it opens up so many other avenues of funding and resources that can be put toward insects."

For example, insects do not fall under Oregon's definition of wildlife, but states such as Nebraska and Washington do work to conserve insects. At least 12 states are known to exclude insects from their definition of "wildlife."

Beyond policy changes, there are also solutions that individuals can implement in their own communities to make major improvements.

"One of the positive things about this whole subject is that people can do something themselves," said Goulson. "Insects are everywhere. They're in our backyards, they're in local parks and cities. Making a garden more wildlife-friendly is easy to do: don't use any pesticides, grow some native wildflowers, don't mow the lawn all the time. Simple stuff."

Goulson also mentions other meaningful individual actions that help insects; he advises buying local seasonal organic produce and avoiding meat. But he emphasizes that voting for green policies is the most impactful action individuals can take to aid conservation efforts.

"Politicians should appreciate that there are votes to be had in looking after the planet," Goulson said.

Grames and Wells both feel that people have the power to help insects and avoid the 'doom scenario.' Insects, as a whole, are a resilient group. Their short generation times make them easily adaptable, and their small size enables them to adjust to niches. This 'missing persons' case is a solvable one. If we give them the tools to rebuild, insects will return.

ONE DAY, as I sit in my backyard and breathe in fragrant May air, I hope that the sky will again flutter with red and black as thousands of lovebugs find their partners. These bugs earn their romantic name from their beautiful courtship routine—once they have found their partner, they attach to each other, often remaining in an embrace for the rest of their two-and-a-half day lifetimes. I imagine watching the bugs flit in their pairings, bumping into awnings and bushes and awkwardly navigating the world as a new unit with two heads and 12 legs. I imagine my relief that we saved these unique and devoted lovers from fading into extinction.

OUT OF OFFICE

The Fading Lineage of Rural Democrats

BY **THEO SOTOODEHNIA**

IN THE SPRING OF 2023, Virginia State Senator Creigh Deeds was fighting to beat off a spirited primary challenge. Just as the primary was entering its final stretch, journalist Dwayne Yancey scored a scoop: Deeds was almost completely off the campaign trail for two weeks. He had lost his dog, a beagle named Mila. His days were spent looking for his lost pup.

"For 13 days, I wasn't knocking on doors, I wasn't calling people, I wasn't campaigning," Deeds told the Charlottesville CBS affiliate. "I was just preoccupied with the loss of this precious dog."

For most politicians, leaving the campaign trail in the home stretch of a tough race would be a political catastrophe. Creigh Deeds, though, is no ordinary politician.

Deeds, a two-time candidate for statewide office with a long and distinguished career in the state legislature, is among the last of his kind. He's a rural Democrat who has survived the Democratic Party's 40-year collapse in small-town America. When the new session of the legislature begins in 2024, he may be the only Democrat in the State Senate representing an area outside Virginia's urban crescent, a region that stretches from the Washington D.C. suburbs to Newport News and Virginia Beach in the Tidewater region.

For the last twenty years, Deeds' district has stretched from the college town of Charlottesville to his old home in Bath County along the West Virginia border. Anchored by a growing, increasingly liberal city in Charlottesville and buoyed by his strong personal brand, Deeds never won less than 64 percent of the vote—–and often ran unopposed.

But this year, redistricting shifted his seat east. Under the new lines, Deeds' district kept Charlottesville, lost Bath County and the cities of Covington and Buena Vista, and picked up Eastern Albemarle County, Amherst County, and portions of Louisa County. While his new seat was not significantly more Democratic and contained a majority of his old constituents, Deeds' home was now well outside the district. Deeds had to move two hours east to Charlottesville, over the Blue Ridge Mountains, in order to run for re-election. Young Democrats in Charlottesville smelled opportunity.

Delegate Sally Hudson of Charlottesville soon jumped into the race. When she's not legislating, Hudson is an Economics professor at the University of Virginia. She ran an aggressive and well-funded campaign that aimed to portray Deeds—–who, though he had not lived in Charlottesville, had represented the city in the state legislature for over twenty years—–as a rural interloper who was too conservative for his district. Hudson herself has lived in Charlottesville for about a decade, but is not originally from Virginia.

"He moved here from almost two hours away," Hudson told CVille Weekly, an alternative newspaper in Charlottesville.

On the issues, Hudson acknowledged there were not substantive policy differences between their two campaigns, but pointed to positions Deeds took in the past as evidence of his insufficiently progressive impulses. The most prominent of these critiques involved gun control—Deeds had a mixed record on gun legislation, and had been endorsed by the NRA in 2005.

"I reserve the right to know more tomorrow than I do today," Deeds told The Politic. "The changes that are reflected in me are just a reflection of the changes in the Democratic Party and in society." In 2023, Deeds sponsored a bill to ban assault weapons.

But Hudson's critique was not that Deeds still held conservative positions—–it was that his past views showed he was not the right choice for Charlottesville, a liberal college town.

Politicians like Deeds' were not always so unusual. Democrats used to be the rule, not the exception, in much of southern and western Virginia.

When Deeds was first elected to the state senate in 1991, there were only two Republicans who represented the area surrounding his district. "You could basically draw a line from Virginia Beach to the Cumberland Gap, they were all Democrats," Deeds said.

In the 1996 Warner v. Warner Senate election, in which future Governor and Senator Mark Warner lost narrowly to long-time incumbent Republican Senator John Warner, it was moderate and liberal Republicans in the D.C. suburbs that put John Warner over the edge. Mark Warner, the Democrat, performed best in rural southern and western Virginia. In 2001, the year Senator Deeds was first elected to the state senate, the Democratic Warner won Deeds' home county, Bath, in his successful bid for governor. In 1996, Bill Clinton won Bath County. In 2020, Joe Biden failed to break thirty percent of the vote.

It's not just rural Virginia's political cartography that has shifted: the very experience of living in small-town America has transformed over the course of Deeds' life.

"When I was growing up way out in the country in Bath County, we got the Staunton newspaper, the Covington newspaper everyday," Deeds said. "My research tool was a set of encyclopedias that my grandmother bought off a traveling salesman in 1962."

Senator Deeds' kids, born in the late 1980s and early 90s, grew up four miles from the house their forebears built when they settled the county, then at the edge of the colonial United States, in the 1740s. Unlike their father, they grew up in the Information Age. The collective knowledge of the world was at their fingertips.

Before the Internet, information was, in effect, curated in two manners: locally, by robust regional newspapers, and nationally, by distant executives in the CBS, ABC, and NBC offices in New York. Information was closer to communities, in the form of dogged local journalists—shoe-leather beat reporters who attended every high school football game, sentencing hearing, and mayoral press conference. But it was also farther away, in the form of Walter Cronkite or Chet Huntley or the bound leather of The World Book encyclopedias.

"People didn't have to go into town as much because they could get what they needed in their local communities. And there was a greater sense of community," Deeds noted. "I think that the transformation of the Information Age and the transformation of the transportation system has made our communities much larger."

These changes are not unique to Deeds' experience. Small towns across the United States have been hollowed out over the last half century. Between the 2010 and 2020 censuses, less than a third of rural counties grew in population. The U.S. has only one-third of the number of banks it had in the 1980s. The banks that have survived are larger—–part of a broader trend

of corporate consolidation that has led to the decline of the American mittelstand, the small and mid-size businesses that anchored so many small American cities and the rural regions that surround them. Young people leave for school and do not come back.

Population in rural America declined for the first time between the 2010 census and 2020 census, driven in large part by youth out-migration. The rural counties that have seen growth are largely outdoor-recreation hubs or popular retirement destinations—places like Flathead County Montana or the Ozarks in Missouri. The number of farmers in the U.S. has declined by 5 million over the last century. Colleges in rural America are closing or cutting programs.

Democratic struggles in rural America have not been confined to Virginia. In 2000, the four states with the highest proportion of their GDP coming from agriculture—South Dakota, Nebraska, North Dakota, and Iowa—sent six Democrats and two Republicans to the Senate. In 2008, they sent five Democrats and three Republicans to the Senate. In 2022, South Dakota, Nebraska, North Dakota, and Iowa sent zero Democrats to the Senate.

This problem is not new. Democrats have bemoaned their party's struggle in rural America for twenty years. Former DNC Chair Howard Dean made confronting the issue a centerpiece of his DNC Chairmanship, calling it his "50-State Strategy." Dean believed investing in basic organizing infrastructure across the country would allow the party to build support in regions where it has not traditionally thrived. In the process, Dean believed the party would activate new, low-propensity voters who Democrats had previously failed to reach and be better able to take advantage of unexpected opportunities.

As Chairman, Dean put his plan into action. During his four-year tenure, Democrats scored impressive wins across the country—including surprise flips of Senate seats in Montana and Alaska. It is difficult to separate the specific effect of Dean's strategy from other factors in Democratic successes in 2006 and 2008. But it's clear that since Dean's tenure ended and the Democratic Party shifted away from investments in hard-to-win states, Democratic performance in rural America has gotten significantly worse. In 2008, Barack Obama won 455 rural counties. In 2020, Joe Biden won 194.

"The American people have not lost their minds," Dean said. "When we run good candidates, then we can win, or we do well."

The problem, he argues, is a lack of resources and effort.

"You have to have candidates who are willing to be there, and you have to have an organization. And frankly, the Democratic Party has not supported the organization in the states the way they should, that's beginning to change," Dean told The Politic "But it's very slow, because Washington is always about the people in Washington, and they forget that everybody else actually really matters in this country."

Dean's strategy always had skeptics, who believed the plan reallocated resources to unwinnable races. When Obama won the presidency, many of those skeptics were swept into the White House. Rahm Emmanuel, whose opposition to Dean's strategy is well-documented, became Obama's first chief of staff. David Axelrod, Obama's lead political strategist and campaign guru, and Chuck Schumer, now the Senate Majority Leader, were also reported to oppose the 50-state strategy. Democratic strategist Paul Begala once described Dean's strategy as "hiring a bunch of staff people to wander around Utah and Mississippi and pick their nose."

The ground game Dean had built at the DNC was dismantled after his tenure ended in 2009. Instead of folding its operations in with the DNC, the Obama campaign maintained its separate structure, Obama for America (later renamed Organizing for America). This parallel organization hoovered up donations, leaving the DNC out of decision-making.

The upside of maintaining this separate structure was that it gave Obama's team complete and direct control over its strategy; the downside was that it starved state and local Democratic parties of resources. This was a particularly damaging time to direct funding away from races in rural areas: precisely as Democrats moved away from Dean's fifty-state strategy, Republicans unleashed a wave of spending on state legislative races. This was part of Operation REDMAP, the Republican Party's attempt to gain control of redistricting in as many states as possible after the 2010 Census.

Maps drawn by Republicans during the 2010 redistricting cycle have created enduring Republican majorities for the last decade and a half. The results speak for themselves—–over the course of the Obama administration, Democrats lost 958 state legislators, 12 governors, and scores of other statewide officeholders.

"It was a disaster for eight years," Dean continued. "I don't think they have ever recovered from that."

It is not just a lack of financial resources that hamper Democrats in rural America. Compared to Republicans, Democrats haven't made as much of an effort to craft a message that appeals to rural Americans, according to Dean.

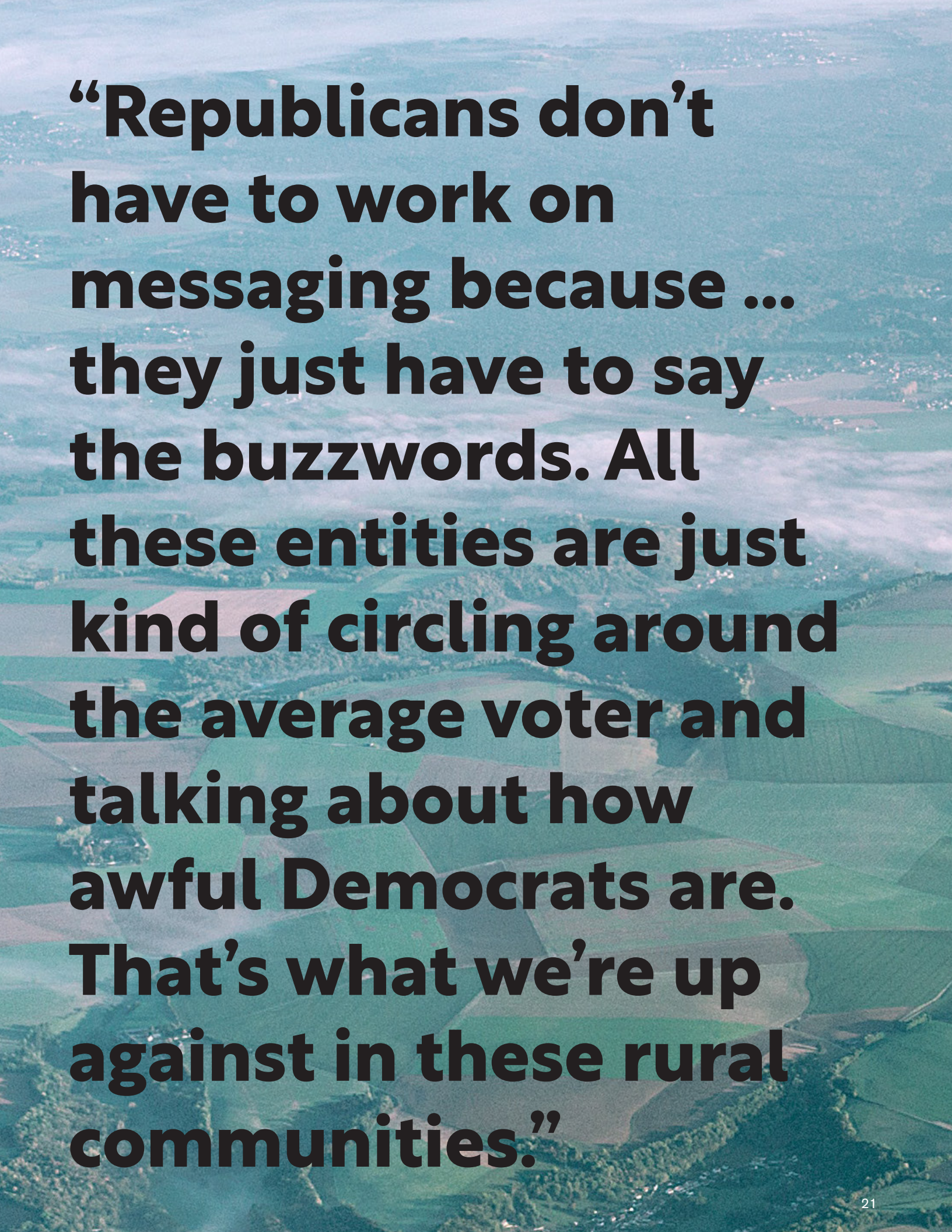
"We don't win the elections we should win because we're terrible at messaging," Dean said. "Politics is simply war by other means," he continued, invoking the words of the 19th-century German general Carl von Clausewitz. "The Republicans win more than they should because they're much better organized. And if you're organized in war, you can win."

Many important Democratic voices on the party's struggle in rural America home in on three interconnected themes. The first problem they identify is a lack of understanding: Democrats do not invest the requisite effort to understand rural voters' concerns.

Delegate Sam Rasoul, who represents the Roanoke area in the Virginia House of Delegates, noted that recent Democratic statewide candidates have spent less time courting voters in small cities and rural areas than they have in the past, choosing to invest time and resources in more competitive races.

"When I first got started in 2007 running for office, the Buena Vista and Covington Labor Day parades were coveted events that everyone went to—–in particular, the statewide candidates," Rasoul recalled. "And then for the first time in 2017, after many, many decades, the Democratic statewide ticket decided not to attend."

Covington and Buena Vista, old industrial towns, have historically been bastions of Democratic support in rural



“Republicans don’t have to work on messaging because … they just have to say the buzzwords. All these entities are just kind of circling around the average voter and talking about how awful Democrats are. That’s what we’re up against in these rural communities.”

"As long as they get the pr
Senate, it doesn't seem lik
about anything else," she
rural America 60-40. Now
We can't be a majority par
lose rural America 80-20."

western Virginia. Their Labor Day parades have long served as the unofficial kickoff for campaign season in western Virginia. That's changed.

"Some consultants told them all the votes are in the urban crescent," Rasoul said, explaining why Democrats have stopped attending the popular annual events. "It's that kind of mentality that left hundreds of thousands, if not millions, of Democrats essentially without the tradition of being represented."

Rural Democrats in other parts of the country echoed Rasoul's sentiment.

"There's really no secret sauce, it's just going anywhere and everywhere, talking to everybody," said Democrat J.D. Scholten, an Iowa State Representative who vaulted onto the national stage when he almost beat former Representative Steve King in 2018.

Before serving as DNC Chairman, Dean was the Governor of Vermont for five terms. He echoed Scholten's sentiment. "I campaigned very hard when I was running for governor in areas that I knew I was gonna get clobbered. You have to respect people, they may not vote for you, but you have to respect them, and that will pay you back," Dean said.

The second problem identified by critics of the Democratic approach to rural outreach is urban liberals' sense of entitlement. Many Democratsare frustrated that Republicans have such a lock on the rural vote. This frustration is exemplified by some liberals' complaints that rural voters "vote against their interests" when they support the GOP. It's such a common gripe that it's referenced in nearly every article criticizing Democrats for their challenges garnering support in rural regions.

This belief, that the superiority of Democratic policies entitles them to rural votes, leads Democrats to avoid the hard work of tailoring their message to rural audiences.

Rural broadband is an example of this lack of tact. Broadband is crucial infrastructure, but, as Democrats' failures show, it's not enough to win an election. Political observer J. Miles Coleman, Senator Heitkamp, and State Representative Scholten all cited Democrats' rhetorical reliance on broadband as an example of the Democratic Party's lack of effort to reach out and understand rural voters.

"Democrats will talk about rural broadband, but it's like, okay, after, after a few elections, you need to throw something else in there," Coleman said.

"Democrats were like, Okay, well, they should be happy because we got them broadband, they should be happy because we passed the Farm Bill," Heitkamp said "And there wasn't the kind of ongoing dialogue with people in the communities."

Heitkamp, Scholten, and Coleman are not saying that rural voters do not care about broadband, or that Democrats have not improved broadband infrastructure. They're gesturing toward the idea that Democrats believe policy alone should be enough to win them rural votes. Their critique is that these same Democrats fail to show up and engage with rural voters—while they fail to ask rural voters what matters to them.

Beyond their lack of engagement, Democrats have a built-in messaging disadvantage in many rural communities. Talk radio is the dominant form of media in much of America and is overwhelmingly conservative. Fox News is the most watched

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cable network. Voters know the Republican message because they hear it through their car’s radio, through the TV in the corner of the local bar, and through their Facebook feed.

“Republicans don’t have to work on messaging because, whether it comes from Fox or OAN or whatever, they just have to say the buzzwords,” said Scholten. “All these entities are just kind of circling around the average voter and talking about how awful Democrats are. That’s what we’re up against in these rural communities.”

Scholten highlighted the role that conservative talk radio has played in this disconnect. The consolidation and decline of local newspapers has left many towns reliant on the radio for news and community information.

“If you go into a smaller town, you go on Main Street, almost every workplace on that street has that one radio station on,” Scholten said.

The Sean Hannity Show, a conservative radio show, is broadcast daily on over 500 stations nationwide. Glenn Beck and Mark Levin’s shows, also conservative, reach over 400 stations.

“I look across the state of Iowa, I believe there’s 22 talk radio stations,” Scholten said. “And so what do we do, we might run like a thirty-second ad with a month left several times a week on those stations—that doesn’t compete with that level of just bashing the Democratic Party.”

Dean echoed Scholten’s sentiments. “Republicans get to deliver their version of the Democratic message,” he explained. “It’s not an effective way to win.”

There is a simple and compelling counter argument often offered to those who worry about Democratic losses in rural areas: it does not matter. Why should the party care if it loses 80-20 in rural America, if it still wins elections?

But this argument seems to contradict the Democratic Party’s belief in representation, its commitment to making sure diverse voices are heard. Their party platform says so explicitly: “Democrats are the party of inclusion. We know that diversity is not our problem—it is our promise. As Democrats, we respect differences of perspective and belief.” The position of the Democratic Party is that the variety of the American experience should be celebrated, that it is important for all voices heard.

“There’s an ethical imperative for the party, as we believe fundamentally in equity in all of its forms,” delegate Rasoul said. “If that is a fundamental value of the party, more so than any other party, we should be investing time, energy and resources as equitably as possible in all corners of America.”

Governor Dean put it more bluntly: “People who argue that we don’t need rural America are just plain dumb,” he said. “It’s a classic Washington argument. ‘Oh, we’re important and nobody else is because they’re not as well educated as we are,’”

Senator Heitkamp highlighted the issue through a different lens. “As long as they get the presidency and the Senate, it doesn’t seem like they care a whole lot about anything else,” she said. “We used to lose rural America 60-40. Now we’re losing it 80-20. We can’t be a majority party, as I have said, and lose rural America 80-20.”

Misconceptions about the demographics of rural America also influence many liberals’ response to their struggle to appeal to rural voters: that rural America is

white America. But rural populations are diverse, and are growing more so. A quarter of rural Americans are people of color. Large parts of the rural South are majority- or plurality-Black. Much of rural California and Texas are majority-Hispanic. There are significant Indigenous populations across the mountain West. But these rural voters of color, like so many other rural voters, are not being adequately served.

Deeds pointed to Virginia's rural Black population—especially those residents along the coast of the Chesapeake Bay on the Northern Neck or the Eastern Shore—as an example of a group that elected officials aren't reaching. "They need to be talked to. They need to be heard," he said.

WHEN DEMOCRATIC INCUMBENTS in rural America retire, they are rarely succeeded by Democrats. Tim Johnson of South Dakota, Tom Harkin of Iowa, Jay Rockefeller of West Virginia, Byron Dorgan of North Dakota—Democratic Senators who retired in 2012 or 2014—were all succeeded by Republicans. Each of these Democrats is the last of a long line of progressive politicians in their state. With each of their losses comes a loss of Democrats' cultural knowledge and institutional power.

The loss of incumbency kneecaps state parties. Holding office allows politicians to mentor future generations and build a lasting web of aides, operatives, and local officials. Democratic Senators, Governors, and other elected officials hire liberal interns from their states. Lobbyists, associations, and pressure groups hire politicians' former staffers. If the party holds no office, this entire ecosystem shrivels and dies. Young interns work for politicians from other states, establishing networks there instead of at home. Local lobbying firms do not hire Democratic ex-staffers, because the Democratic Party is irrelevant to their clients. The talent pipeline runs dry.

State Senator Creigh Deeds is another final survivor of a long line of rural Democrats.

"I'm the last one that has a strong connection to a rural area in western Virginia, and I think I do have a voice," Deeds said. "In the modern Democratic Party, the forces are primarily in Northern Virginia and Hampton Roads, Richmond."

"But the reality is that people everywhere deserve representation," he continued. "And I'm the only person that really has a lot of experience representing rural areas. I'm the only person in the Democratic leadership that has the experience of growing up in a rural area."

In his primary last spring, Deeds edged out Sally Hudson by less than five hundred votes. Had she triumphed instead, Deeds would have been replaced by an academic who grew up elsewhere. Assuming he wins the general election in his D+17 seat, for the next 4 years, Deeds will be one of the only voices for rural Virginians in the Democratic caucus in Richmond.

Yet Deeds' seat is dominated by Charlottesville and Albemarle County, the increasingly populous and liberal area surrounding it. When Deeds retires, it is unlikely his successor will have comparable ties to rural Virginia. But his eventual retreat from public life will be another step in the slow bifurcation of America, another step away from unity and towards division.

The loss of rural Democrats weighs on Deeds. The Democratic Party has changed since he was first elected—for the better, in many ways. It's become committed to representing the diversity of the American experience and leveraging the power of government to improve the lives of all Americans. In this mission, Democrats have made much progress. But they have largely left rural voters behind.

"We've got to be able to speak to people everywhere," Deeds said. "It breaks my heart."

The Fight over New York City Classrooms

BY **MIRA DUBLER-FURMAN**

DOWNSIZED

"THAT WOULD TAKE 20 YEARS," Leonie Haimson said when asked to outline her involvement with New York City public school advocacy. She isn't exaggerating. Haimson is the founder and director of Class Size Matters, a non-profit she formed in 2000 that is devoted to lowering the number of students per class in the city's public schools.

So, in September 2022, when New York Governor Kathy Hochul signed a bill into law that would significantly lower the number of students permitted per class in NYC, Haimson was ecstatic. Her life's mission was one step closer to becoming a reality.

New York lawmakers passed the class size measure in May 2022, and after negotiations, Hochul signed it on September 8. The law marks a significant shift in policy, with the structure of the state's public education set to change dramatically. Kindergarten and first through third grades were previously capped at 25 and 32 students, respectively. Those grades are now required to have a maximum of 20 students per class. For fourth through eighth grades, the previous limits mandated class sizes between 30-32 students. That number is now 23. And high schools, formerly permitted up to 34 students in each classroom, are now restricted to 25. The law mandates that each year, beginning in 2023, an additional 20% of schools must be in compliance, with 100% of classrooms achieving the new caps by 2028.

Haimson argues that lowering class size numbers is unequivocally good for education. She recalls a memory from two decades ago when she dropped off her 1st-grade daughter in a classroom filled with 29 students. "Her teacher confided to me one day that it made all the difference in the world when one or two kids were absent," Haimson said. Thus began her crusade to shrink classes.

Haimson's experience is a relatable one for many New York City parents and teachers. Improving public schools is a universal desire, and as class size reduction is a tangible policy change, it garners strong parent support. A poll from 2007 found that 77% of the American public preferred dedicating education funding to reducing class size rather than increasing teacher salaries. And a survey of parents from the 2020-2021 school year found that smaller class sizes was the most popular reform, after stronger enrichment programs and more hands-on learning. Teachers express similar sentiments: one study found that 90% of teachers believed small classes would have a very strong or strong impact on learning.

"A lot of high school class sizes are above 30," Josh Torpey, a humanities teacher for 7th and 12th grade students at a public school in Manhattan, told *The Politic*. "I think it's terrible that we have so many classes in the city with such big class sizes."

United Federation of Teachers (UFT), the New York City teachers' union, played a large role in the law's passage. Christina Collins, director of education policy for the union, said that union members were overwhelmingly supportive of the measure. "Our members really consistently have said this is the time to do it," Collins said. "The sooner, the better."

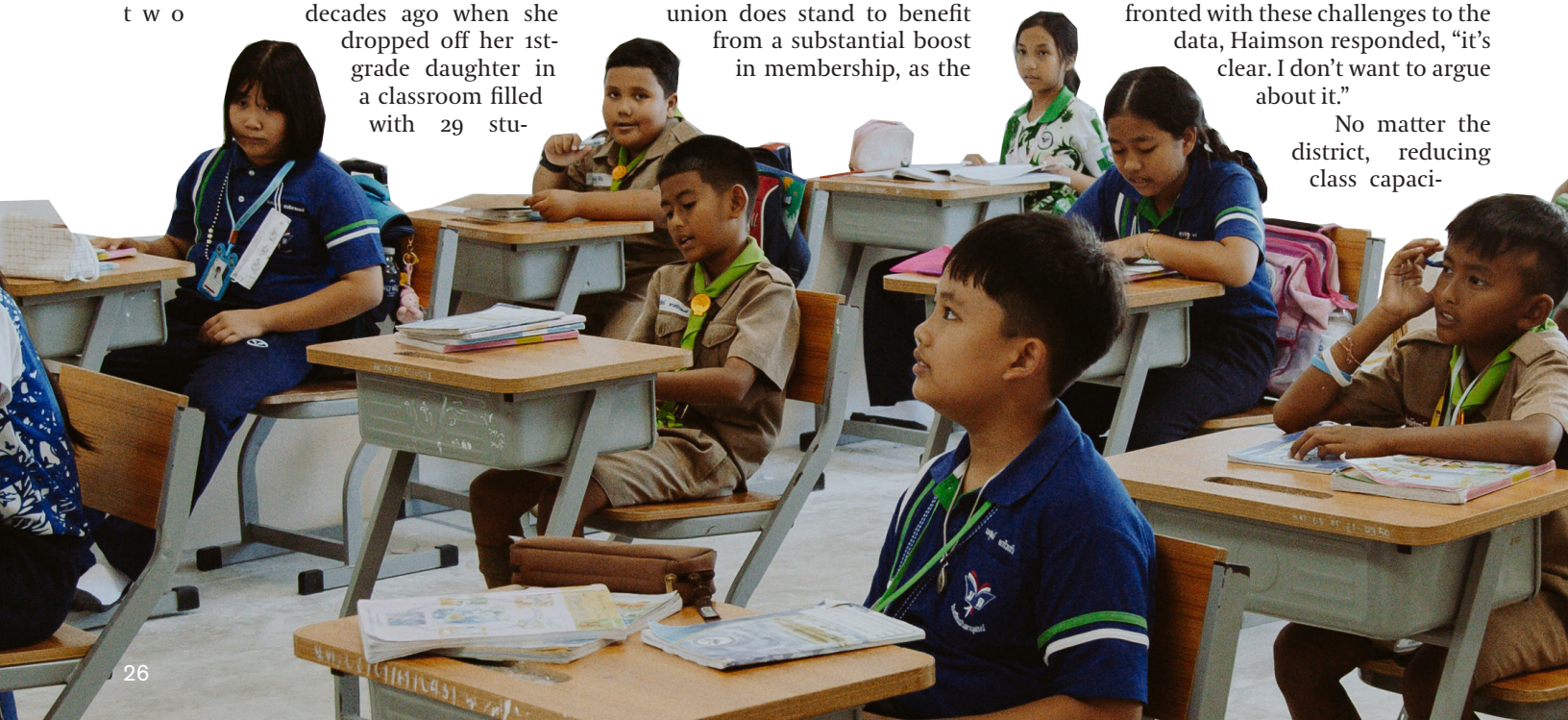
If the new limits are enforced, the union does stand to benefit from a substantial boost in membership, as the city will be required to hire more teachers to accommodate the new classes. But Collins emphasized that this is an issue teachers are passionate about. "We do have higher class sizes than many other districts. And that's been a point of concern for our members for a long time."

The bill was also politically popular. In Albany, the measure passed 59-4 in the NYS Senate and 147-2 in the NYS Assembly, garnering bipartisan support. New York State Senator John Liu was a sponsor of the new law, and believes that it was a long overdue reform.

"The class size bill should not have been necessary," Liu, who represents Queens, said. "The city of New York should have known that it needs to comply with the state constitution to provide a sound basic education for every school kid."

But the benefits of class size reduction for learning are more complicated than this widespread political support seems to reflect. Most of the evidence that points to the educational effectiveness of lowering class sizes originates from a study conducted by the Tennessee Department of Education between 1985 and 1989, commonly referred to as STAR (Student/Teacher Achievement Ratio). STAR shows strong results for small classes in lower grades, although the study concluded that the benefit of small classes grows smaller as students get older. Other research disagrees. One 2007 study by researchers at Duke found that the quality of the teacher is nearly 24 times more impactful on student learning than reducing the number of students in a classroom. When confronted with these challenges to the data, Haimson responded, "it's clear. I don't want to argue about it."

No matter the district, reducing class capaci-



ties is extremely expensive. The New York state bill, which is not directly funded, is estimated to cost almost $2 billion. New York City's Independent Budget Office found that the district would have to hire a total of 17,700 new teachers to accommodate the necessary restructuring and addition of classes. The budget office clarified that this price tag does not even include the resources that may be required to build additional space for shrinking classes. Proponents of the bill are not blind to these challenges. The working group tasked with examining the law's implementation released initial recommendations to the city to "aggressively pursue new opportunities for potential funding."

FOR THE PAST 15 YEARS, Josh Solomon has been a principal at the Business of Sports School (BOSS) in New York City. BOSS is a public high school of under 500 students in midtown Manhattan where the vast majority of students are Black or Hispanic. 90% of his students are below the poverty line. Solomon understands the class size predicament from a head of school's perspective – both its benefits and detriments.

If one is asked whether they're in favor of smaller class sizes, "everyone will say yes," claimed Solomon. But he emphasized that this consensus becomes messier because of the difficulties of implementation. "Well, are we reducing everyone's raises so that we can pay for more teachers to give smaller classes? Now, does everyone say yes? Are we going to cut all services…let's cut down on music and sports funding and art so that we can have smaller class sizes?"

If this new law is to be fully implemented, the city will inevitably have to reduce other forms of spending, as they are forced to spend more of their allocated budget on hiring thousands of teachers and finding schools more physical space.

Principals like himself are focused on the day-to-day challenges of educating NYC youth, not tackling the uphill battle of reducing the city's class sizes

Solomon's questions underscore a central dilemma that critics often point out about the bill: education policies come at the cost of other initiatives. Funding is not unlimited – far from it, particularly in New York City. If this new law is to be fully implemented, the city will inevitably have to reduce other forms of spending, as they are forced to spend more of their allocated budget on hiring thousands of teachers and finding schools more physical space.

"What would I do?" Solomon said, when asked what will happen if each school is assessed for its class sizes' compliance. "Ask for another building?" he continued. "Yeah, that's not gonna happen. Ask them to, like, close one of the schools in my building? Ask them to take out, you know, 100 kids from my school, but give me the same money? Like, I don't see any of these things [happening]."

The critiques of this law are not only questions of theoretical tradeoffs. The ways in which the new policy will impact NYC is far from clear, and some data indicates it will further increase education inequality. According to the Department of Education's data, within the 39% of NYC classes that already meet the new law's standards, schools with a higher percentage of disadvantaged students are more likely to be in compliance, not less. In contrast, schools with larger affluent populations are more likely to be overcrowded, with class sizes that are above the new law's caps. The quarter of city public schools with the lowest income students is already at 59% of classes meeting the new standards, compared to only 23% of classes in schools with the wealthiest quarter of students.

What does this mean for the implementation of the new law? Many of the

"IN THIS CASE, EQUA

overcrowded schools that this bill seeks to address are already relatively wealthy, academically-strong schools.

In some people's minds, overcrowded schools are assumed to be institutions that lack adequate funding and provide students with poorer educations. But in NYC, this is largely not the case. As former NYC public school student Theo Kubovy-Weiss said, "class sizes at Stuyvesant were quite large, usually over 31, 32 students." Stuyvesant High School, the school that Kubovy-Weiss attended, is ranked as the fourth best public high school in the city. His experience reflects the data – stronger schools often have larger classes. Given that funding is allocated per student, New York City awards large portions of funding to highly-enrolled schools like Stuyvesant.

Furthermore, well-funded schools tend to have larger populations of white and Asian students, while under-resourced schools in the city generally have larger Black and Hispanic populations. According to a 2017 study, only 15% of the students at the city's top schools are Black or Hispanic, demographics that make up around 70% of the city's total number of public school students.

These data points lead to perhaps the biggest critique of the 2022 law: If under-resourced schools with larger Black and Latino populations are also the under-enrolled institutions, this bill is unlikely to have any impact on them, let alone improve their educational standing. "In this case, equal is less equitable," said Matthew Chingos, Vice President for Education Data & Policy at the Urban Institute.

"Bullshit," Haimson said in response to this criticism, not mincing her words. "The highest-need schools tend to have a somewhat larger number of smaller classes than other schools," she admitted. But she maintained that the recent legal measure will nevertheless help "Black, Hispanic, low income, and English language learners," because there are large numbers of these demographics in the whole NYC public school system. As Senator Liu put it, "the vast majority of school districts in New York City are still considered needy, and many of them still have overcrowded classes." He called the criticism of his bill a "red herring."

Solomon disagreed. "In areas of Harlem – there are many schools that are struggling to get, like 100 or 200 students. So from a school size, those schools are really shrinking rapidly," he said. With the new law, "most of the benefit would be [for] the wealthier schools. And most of the other schools would just lose budget, because that 2 billion dollars is going to need to come from somewhere."

PETER KARP IS THE PRINCIPAL at the Institute for Collaborative Education (ICE), a public school in lower Manhattan that serves sixth through ninth graders. ICE prides itself on its small classes, and Karp said that in turn, the school forgoes potential funding that is calculated per student. Karp said he is generally supportive of the legislation, and is pleased that it passed. But he knows the complicated nature of education policy and the diverse issues facing education in NYC.

"There's too many layers, in my opinion, to say this one thing is the bullet," he said. "There's no magic bullet."

Solomon echoed this sentiment, saying of the measure, "it's kind of like looking at [education policy] as the Garden of Eden, you know?" Whether or not the 2022 law will improve education, many educators are in agreement: it is not the all-in-one fix that it is made out to be.

It is now the job of a New York City working group composed of around 50 members–teachers, parents, advocates, and government officials–to recommend a plan for implementing the law. They will advise the city on if it's possible to make this proverbial Garden of Eden a reality. The working group's recommendations for the implementation of the plan will be released by the end of October 2023. Haimson is also a member of the committee, though she would not comment on its inner workings.

Dia Bryant, Director of the Education Trust and former New York City principal, is a member of the working group. Bryant is concerned that the group is not focused enough on how the law might negatively impact high-need schools. "Talking about class size in a vacuum misses what we know about urban schooling," Bryant said. She went on to describe how, in her view, some members of the working group are only concerned with implementing the new caps exactly as they are described in the bill or examining the intricacies of high-achieving schools in NYC. As a former public school principal, Bryant wants to ensure the conversation also includes questions of equity.

Solomon, who is not a member of the committee, labeled the bill as unrealistic and unachievable. He conveyed that principals like himself are focused on the day-to-day challenges of educating NYC youth, not tackling the uphill battle of reducing the city's class sizes. "The law is not a factor in my life. It's something in the news, I have not thought about it," he said.

Whether the class size law will improve education in New York City — and if it will even be implemented as planned — is yet to be determined. But Haimson will not be deterred: she and her supporters are confident in the law's potential to remedy a deeply flawed system. "It's a tragedy," she said, "that in the richest city, in the richest country in the world, we have kids attending school in third world conditions."

L IS LESS EQUITABLE"

BEYOND THE HEADLINES

BY **ELIZA DAUNT**

An Interview with Mishal Husain

Mishal Husain is an award-winning British broadcaster and presente, best known for her reporting at BBC News. In 2016, Husain was named by the Sunday Times *as one of the 500 most influential people in Britain and one of the five most influential Muslim women in the UK. Before attending Cambridge University to read law, Husain gained her first experience in journalism at the age of 18 when she spent three months as a city reporter in Islamabad. In 2002, she became the BBC's first Washington-based anchor, covering the build-up to the invasion of Iraq. Since then, she has reported from Cairo during the Egyptian Revolution, Pakistan after the deaths of Osama bin Laden and Benazir Bhutto, and Peshawar after the deadly 2014 Taliban school attack, covered UK elections, the Brexit referendum and Harry and Megan's first interview together, on their engagement in 2017. She is currently one of the anchor presenters of BBC Radio 4's* The Today program, *the premier news broadcast in the UK, and presents news bulletins on BBC One.*

Parts of this interview have been edited for clarity.

Mishal Husain by Willstar

Candlelight vigil in London for the victims of the Peshawar school siege by Kashif Haque

YOU GAINED YOUR FIRST EXPERIENCE IN JOURNALISM AT THE AGE OF 18 WHEN YOU SPENT THREE MONTHS AS A CITY REPORTER IN ISLAMABAD. WHAT ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE YOUR YOUNGER SELF NOW?

When I look back now, I thought of journalism as an independent exercise: get an assignment, go off, come back, write it up, and deliver it. Newsrooms can be quite a daunting place. It always feels like everyone knows each other if you're a newcomer. Because of my lack of confidence, I didn't take the time to try and get to know people. What I love about broadcasting is that you don't have that option. You cannot put a radio or TV program on air without a team. There's such a wonderful aspect of people with different skills working together.

REFLECTING ON YOUR STRONG PERSONAL CONNECTION TO PAKISTAN, BOTH GROWING UP THERE AND STARTING YOUR CAREER AS A YOUNG REPORTER. I WANTED TO ASK ABOUT YOUR COVERAGE OF THE PESHAWAR SCHOOL MASSACRE IN 2014, WHEN THE TALIBAN KILLED 132 CHILDREN AND 16 TEACHERS. WHAT WAS IT LIKE BEING THE FIRST JOURNALIST TO ENTER THE ARMY SCHOOL AFTER SUCH A VIOLENT EVENT?

[The shooting] had happened in the morning, our time in the UK. My editor phoned me and said, could you get on a plane today? I said yes. It was coming up to Christmas and my children were relatively young at the time, but I thought that this was such an important story. I got on a plane and got to Islamabad early the next morning. It was just me and a producer. We drove three hours to Peshawar and went straight to the school.

Still relatively early in the morning, we stood outside the school with a cameraman from the BBC team in Islamabad. Many journalists were there but word came down to the soldiers at the gate that they could let me in, and the doors opened. Just two of us went in - myself and the cameraman.

It was such a terrible story that I have never, and will never, call it a scoop. I think that's such a disrespectful term for the fact that I had this strange privilege, strange because I think I was just in the right place at the right time, to be one of the two people that they allowed in first. There was a path going up to the school, and there were a few soldiers lining it. They'd spent the night clearing the bodies, but everything else was still there. The blood, broken glass, the shoes, glasses, books, everything that had just been dropped.

It was the strangest experience to walk through the site right through to this bombed out auditorium where there had been a gunfight, and then through into the headmistresses's office, where ultimately, suicide bombers had blown themselves up. I thought we're going to walk through, and I have one shot at recording what I see for both TV and radio. Our technical facilities were very limited, but we managed to film, come straight out and go on air live.

To this day, I haven't watched it back, partly because I will see so many things that I could have done better. But also because I still find it such a shocking thing. School is something we can all relate to, right? However old we are, it's something so poignant. It was not long after the attack on Malala. These kinds of attacks go on today; they are just unspeakable and unimaginable. And yet, we have to speak about them. I saw the aftermath of one for myself. It was absolutely searing.

WHICH OTHER CONFLICT ZONES HAVE MADE A DEEP IMPACT ON YOU?

I have been to Lebanon a couple of times where we broadcast from Syrian refugee camps. I have been to the Rohingya refugee camps in Eastern Bangladesh, and gosh that's a forgotten crisis altogether. I feel really sad that the Rohingyas don't get much attention. I remember looking around that refugee camp and having this very strong feeling that these young children would more than likely, unless there is a massive change in Myanmar,

By Jeff Overs/BBC

spend their whole lives in those tents. That's a very hard thing to think about, I hope I'm wrong.

Those images stay with you but you are also [in conflict zones] to do a certain job. That gives you a purpose and keeps you very focused. Any time you are in those situations, you've got deadlines to meet, so everything you absorb is channeling you towards a certain end point which is to tell the story to your audience. At least for me — and I have not been exposed to some of the very extreme things that some of my colleagues have been exposed to — the mechanics of telling the story and getting on air has helped provide some kind of framework around the things you see.

AS A WASHINGTON CORRESPONDENT TO THE BBC, YOU COVERED THE 9/11 ATTACKS. A FRIEND OF YOURS REMARKED THAT THEY COULD NOT IMAGINE ANYONE WITH A LAST NAME LIKE YOURS BEING ON AMERICAN TELEVISION DOING THE JOB THAT YOU DO. WHAT CHANGES HAVE YOU FELT AS A MUSLIM WOMAN THROUGHOUT YOUR CAREER?

I started my role as Washington correspondent to the BBC in September 2002, at a time of great tension. Afghanistan was underway, Iraq was coming. One of my earliest assignments was to cover the first anniversary of 9/11 at the Pentagon. My family is from Pakistan, a country that was immediately affected by those attacks.

I was in the very rare position then of being a Muslim fronting a news program in the States. Given my name, it's an obvious aspect of my identity. It was a very odd spotlight to be in, and I struggled with it at times. That aspect of my identity was noticeable in America then in a way I had never experienced in the UK. I remember being in a department store, and a cashier spotted my name and asked me if I was related to Saddam Hussein. It was very odd. You don't know whether to laugh or cry at a moment like that.

Thankfully, it's different now. I see several anchors of Muslim heritage in high-profile positions.

It was a very odd spotlight to be in, and I struggled with it at times. That aspect of my identity was noticeable in America then in a way I had never experienced in the UK.

WERE THERE TIMES IN YOUR CAREER IN THE UK WHEN BEING MUSLIM FELT LIKE A PARTICULARLY PROMINENT PART OF YOUR IDENTITY?

Most of the time I don't think about it, but certainly the London bombings in 2005, and during the worst period of ISIS in Iraq and Syria between 2014 to 2017. Of course, there are times when I can bring this part of my identity, the knowledge I have through it, into my work, not as a particular point of view, but as a point of information.

CAN YOU DESCRIBE A BIT ABOUT WHAT YOUR JOB INVOLVES AND WHAT YOUR WEEK LOOKS LIKE NOW?

One of the first things to understand about broadcast journalism is that if you're not prepared to work antisocial hours then this probably isn't the job for you.

Radio 4's Today program goes on air at 6, so I get up just after 3 am and cycle to work. You have to be ready to hit the ground running on arrival. Within a quarter of an hour, about 4:15 am UK time, we are recording any guests on the East Coast who, because of the time difference, we've persuaded to stay up late.

One of the biggest challenges about these breakfast-time programs is that they're 24-hour operations so you are constantly inheriting the work that's been done by the team before. It is then your job to carry that forward to its execution point when we go on air. You must be so clear in your communications, otherwise, crucial things get lost. There is a particular dynamic around this, things are always moving. For example, I could ring into the newsroom just before I go to sleep, to find out who I am interviewing the following morning. But in my experience, parts are still moving. Even if they are set, you might spend half the night worrying about the next interview, only to wake up in the morning and realize your interviewee has changed. Get some sleep instead!

WORKING FOR THE BBC, YOU HAVE STRICT IMPARTIALITY RULES WHICH YOU MUST FOLLOW. IN WHICH TOPICS HAVE YOU FOUND IT THE MOST DIFFICULT TO REMAIN IMPARTIAL?

There are parameters around every job. We are in the business of creating good conversation, and to do this you have to finely tune your antenna to ask: what do I need to know about this particular topic or person? It doesn't mean that every single point of view is equally valid or should be treated equally, and it's definitely not always as simple as giving both sides. It's about evaluating arguments all the time, then reaching informed judgements on the validity of those arguments and the extent to which they should be a part of the conversation you're curating. At its core, I feel the heart of any journalistic endeavor is to help us as a planet understand each other better. Our business should be about illuminating, not arguing although argument has its place.

THROUGHOUT YOUR CAREER, YOU'VE INTERVIEWED MANY HIGH-PROFILE FIGURES, FROM AUNG SAN SUU KYI TO PRINCE HARRY AND MEGHAN MARKLE. WHAT STEPS DO YOU TAKE TO PREPARE AND ARE YOU EVER NERVOUS?

With any high-profile interview and an interview of any length, you need to step back for a moment and think, what are the three most important things that I need to get out of this? Anything more than three and the interview becomes unwieldy.

The most important thing to do is listen, it sounds obvious, but it is so easy to just hear and not listen.

Sometimes, someone says something provoking and you have to make a choice – are you going to follow that, or is there something else that you really wanted to ask? You are constantly making split second decisions.

WHAT ADVICE WOULD YOU GIVE TO YOUNG WOMEN STARTING A CAREER IN JOURNALISM?

I feel fortunate that I did not experience some of the things that we are more likely to talk about now, like harassment or outright discrimination. I think the tricker thing for women in journalism now is not so much getting started but coping with the times when you may have to come in and out of the workplace through having children. It means navigating points where you have to re-establish yourself.

Try and keep your options open, because hopefully life is long. Don't rule things out just because they seem impossible at a point of particular juggling. You want to keep as many paths open as possible.

GIVEN THE EMOTIONALLY DEMANDING NATURE OF YOUR JOB, WHAT DO YOU DO TO TAKE CARE OF YOUR OWN WELL-BEING?

One of the most important things that aspiring journalists don't realize is that to do your best work, you have to be disciplined in your personal life. You're going to have to say no to things, you're going to have to be careful not to burn out. Physical well being and physical fitness is all part of making sure that your brain is working as well as it possibly can under pressure. There probably are people who could do my job burning the candle at both ends, but I'm not one of them.

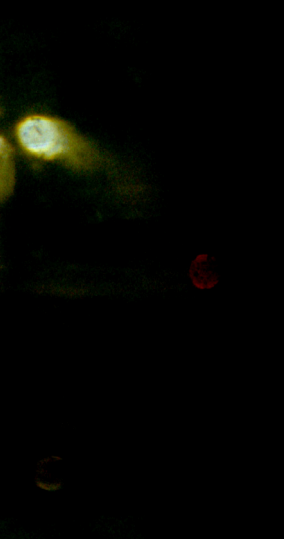
Often I come off air and regret asking certain things. Or not asking certain things! But those evaluations are part of being exacting with yourself. The minute you stop being exacting with yourself, the minute you stop being nervous, is the minute your performance starts declining.

Mishal Husain introduces the awards by AIB London

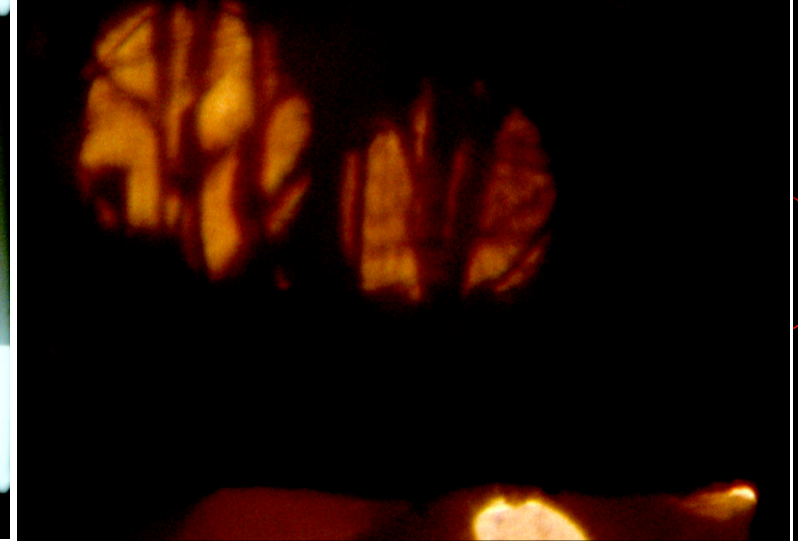
New Haven Line

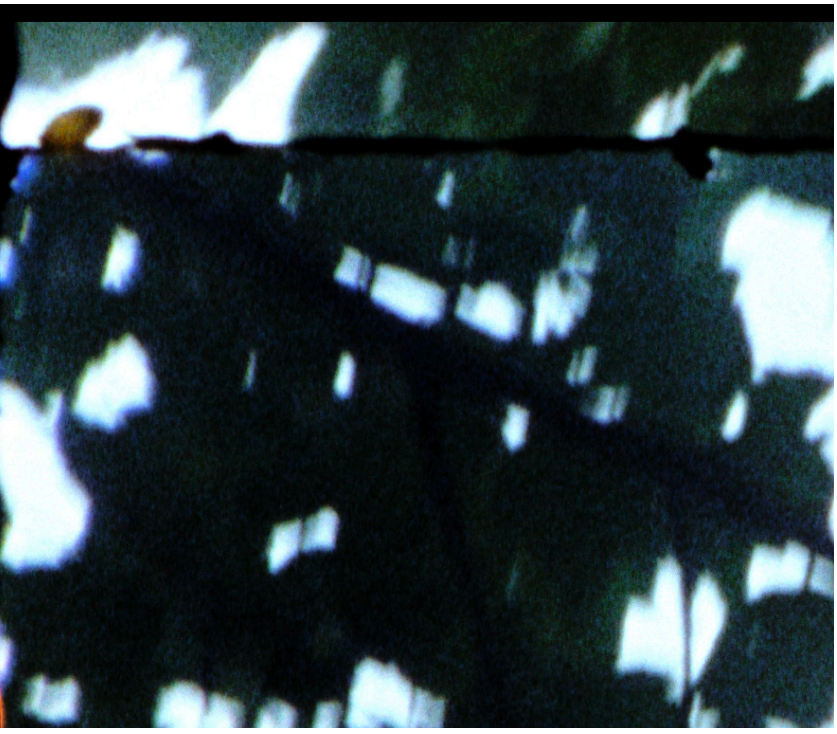
BY **AUDREY COOMBE**

These stills are taken from Super 8 footage shot between New York City and New Haven in 2021, during the pandemic. I recorded these trips with the intention of remembering the often monotonous passages that would otherwise be forgotten. The results: a proof of existence and evidence of the passing of time from winter to spring. Pulling stills undoes the projector's work which embeds the particular image in an encompassing, continuous motion. This project was an experiment in memory, knowing the Super 8's nostalgic grain would influence a viewer's impression of these moments, preserving and recasting these transitory hours from a loaded and voided time. The images' unrevealing contents evoke the missing links between disparate images.



EMERGENCY EXIT





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